If the government had provided the policy and infrastructure support of the type offered under NPSP and NPE for IT services export promotion, we may not have seen the development of our IT services giants. As the IT services business is suited to both large and small businesses, software technology parks offered their services to both and small businesses thrived equally. Electronics hardware and software products, by nature, are more suited to large-scale enterprises.

Policies for IT Infrastructure

Digital infrastructure is built on whatever medium—fibre optics, satellites, spectrum—can carry and store data fast and in huge volumes. In India, digital infrastructure has developed most on spectrum using mobile telephony. Most data is transmitted on spectrum in India as fibre optics has got a relatively short shrift, though it seems to be receiving attention now. Likewise, we have constrained the use of satellites in moving data.

We have fallen into another trap by unimaginatively using digital infrastructure for digitalizing the economy. Just as excessive pricing of land became a constraint on development of industries, excessive pricing of spectrum, especially after the 2G scam, is coming in the way of adoption of digital technologies and would most likely constrain the use of 5G technologies as well.

National Digital Communications Policy, 2018 (NDCP-2018)

The government adopted NDCP-2018, recognizing that ‘digital infrastructure and services are increasingly emerging as key enablers and critical determinants of a country’s growth and well-being’. The policy is vital to achieve two major goals: transforming the economy into a digital one by digitalizing production and distribution of goods; and transforming society, comprising individuals and households, into a digital one.